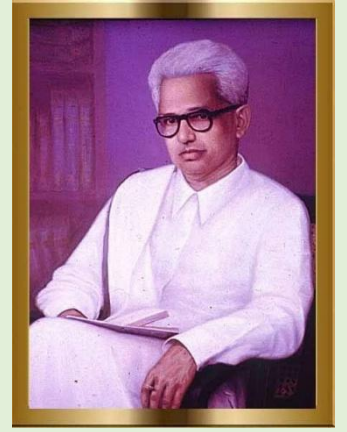


Jnanpith Awardee from Kerala

G. Sankara Kurup (1901–1978) was a celebrated Malayalam poet, essayist, critic, and translator, best known as the first recipient of the Jnanpith Award in 1965 for his poetry collection *Odakkuzhal* (*The Bamboo Flute*).



Mr. G. Sankara Kurup

Malayalam poet and essayist

G. Sankara Kurup, fondly known as *Mahakavi G.*, was the first recipient of the prestigious Jnanpith Award in **1965**, conferred for his renowned poetry collection *Odakkuzhal* (*The Bamboo Flute*), a work that revolutionized Malayalam poetry with its rich symbolism and lyrical elegance. Born on **3 June 1901** in Nayathode, Kerala, Kurup's literary journey spanned poetry, essays, short stories, plays, and translations. His writings reflected a deep engagement with nature, human emotions, and philosophical contemplation, blending traditional aesthetics with modernist sensibilities.

Over his illustrious career, Kurup authored around **25 poetry collections**, notable among them being *Suryakanthi* (Sunflower), *Nimisham* (The Moment), *Padikante Paattu* (The Traveller's Song), *Vishwadarshanam* (Vision of the Universe), *Moonnaruvium Oru Puzhayum* (Three Streams and a River), *Jeevana Sangeetham* (The Music of Life), and *Sahitya Kauthukam*. His Jnanpith-winning *Odakkuzhal* consists of sixty poems that explore universal themes with profound simplicity and musical rhythm. Besides poetry, he made a mark as a prose writer with collections such as *Rajanandini*, *Harischandran*, *Radharaani*, *Mutthum Chippiyum* (Pearl and Oyster), *G-yude Note Book*, and *Ormayude Olangalil* (In the Waves of Memory). Kurup's plays like *Irutinu Munpu* (Before Darkness), *Sandhya*, and *August 15* reflect his engagement with social realities and historical change, while his essays and critical writings contributed immensely to Malayalam literary discourse.

Kurup also played a vital role as a translator, introducing global classics to Malayalam readers through his translations of Rabindranath Tagore's *Gitanjali*, Kālidāsa's *Meghadūta*, and Omar Khayyām's *Rubaiyat*. His works were celebrated for their fusion of Indian tradition with modern thought, earning him not only the Jnanpith but also honors such as the **Kerala Sahitya Akademi Award**, **Sahitya Akademi Award**, **Padma Bhushan**, and the **Soviet Land Nehru Award**. Beyond literature, Kurup served as a nominated member of the **Rajya Sabha** and established the *Odakkuzhal Award* to encourage Malayalam writers.